designation “Farmer”) jet on July 1, 1960. Now they were free. Kennedy announced the release of the pilots on January 25 at the first presidential press conference ever to be televised. He basked in national attention and approval when on January 27 he greeted the returning pilots with their happy wives on their arrival at Andrews Air Force Base.[5]

Khrushchev believed that the young president owed him his victory and expected something in return. “We helped elect Kennedy,” he declared in the summer of 1961 to a group of Soviet political leaders and scientists. “It can be said that we elected him.” Khrushchev wanted a summit meeting as soon as possible in order to assess his opposite number in Washington. Instead of toppling any hopes of a high-level summit, the Cuban debacle only whetted Khrushchev’s appetite for it. An inexperienced president unsure of himself was the best counterpart he could imagine with whom to discuss world affairs. Bruised by the Cuban debacle and seeking to recover his standing in the international arena, John Kennedy stepped into a trap: the two leaders agreed to meet as soon as possible.[6]

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KHRUSHCHEV AND KENNEDY HAD THE FIRST CHANCE TO SIZE each other up on June 3, 1961. The venue was the US embassy in Vienna. But it was Khrushchev rather than Kennedy who felt fully at home, presenting himself as a senior statesman meeting his younger and thus inferior counterpart. He reminded Kennedy that he had arrived late for their first brief meeting in the course of Khrushchev’s visit to the United States at Eisenhower’s invitation back in 1959. They then moved on to discuss Kennedy’s young age. Khrushchev remarked that he would be happy to “share his years with the president.” It was a friendly beginning, but Khrushchev had already established his position of authority.[7]

Back in April the Cuban debacle had seemed to have eliminated any chance of a summit meeting, but Khrushchev had surprised Kennedy by reviving the idea in early May. On May 4, 1961, the Soviet foreign minister, Andrei Gromyko, summoned the American ambassador to the Soviet Union, Llewellyn Thompson, to his office and told him that the Soviet